

INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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Contents

Introduction: The Promise and Vulnerability of Independent, Alternative, and Community Media

David W. Park and Meghan Grosse xvii

PART 1: CONCEPTUALIZING INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA

There is No Alternative: The Critical Potential of Alternative Media in the Face of Neoliberalism

Linus Andersson 1

Uncommunicative Partners: Social Movement Media Analysis and Racial Educators

John D. H. Downing 20

Communication and Struggles for Alternatives

Christian Fuchs 29

What We Talk About When We Talk About "Media Independence"

Karl Karpinnen and Hallvard Moe 43

The Unbearable Lightness of Being Alternative: Idealism-Realism and Purism-Pragmatism in Greek Alternative Media

Dimitra L. Milioni and Pantelis Vatikiotis. 59

PART 2: HISTORY, MEMORY, AND ARCHIVES

Hand-Made Memories: Remediating Cultural Memory in DIY Feminist Networks

Red Chidgey 83

Being a Child of the Mines: Youth Magazines and Comics in the Copperbelt

Enid Guene. 93

Social Participation in Indonesian Media and Art: Echoes from the Past, Visions for the Future

Edwin Jurriëns 112

Learning from the History of Alternative Communication Networks

Félix Tréguer, Dominique Trudel, and Mélanie Dulong de Rosnay 134

A Brief History of CCLM/CLMP

Pauline Uchmanowicz 152

<i>Promising Prospects, and the Hurdles Along the Way: Sharing and Archiving Community Media Content Online</i>	
Joost van Beek.	163

PART 3: POLICY, REGULATIONS, AND GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION

<i>Media at the Margins: Policy and Practice in American, Canadian, and British Community Television</i>	
Christopher Ali	173
<i>News by Any Other Name: Community Radio Journalism in India</i>	
Bridget Backhaus	192
<i>'In the Waiting Room': Digitisation and Post-Neoliberalism in Buenos Aires</i>	
Geoff Baker.	208
<i>From Revolution to Reform: Recommendations for Spectrum Policy in Transitional Tunisia</i>	
Moez Chakchouk, Danielle Kehl, Jochai Ben-Avie, and Kate Coyer.	244
<i>From Media Niche to Policy Spotlight: Mapping Community-Media Policy Change in Latin America</i>	
Arne Hintz	269
<i>Community Radio Contradictions in Canada: Learning from Volunteers Impacted by Commercialising Policies and Practices</i>	
Gretchen King and Omme-Salma Rahemtullah	282

PART 4: PRODUCTION AND DISTRIBUTION

<i>Podcasting About Yourself and Challenging Norms: An Investigation of Independent Women Podcasters in Denmark</i>	
Freja Sørine Adler Berg	305
<i>The Business of DIY: Characteristics, Motives and Ideologies of Microindependent Record Labels</i>	
Robin den Drijver and Erik Hitters	323
<i>Intervention for Inclusivity: Gender Politics and Indie Game Development</i>	
Stephanie Fisher and Alison Harvey	342
<i>From Art House to Your House: The Distribution of Quality Cinema on Home Video</i>	
Daniel Herbert	358
<i>SoundCloud and Bandcamp as Alternative Music Platforms</i>	
David Hesmondhalgh, Ellis Jones, and Andreas Rauh.	373

<i>Indie or Mainstream? Tensions and Nuances between the Alternative and the Mainstream in Indie Games</i>	
Ólivier Pérez-Latorre	393
<i>Making Media Together: Experiences of Aboriginal Participation within Co-Creative Remote Media Production Teams</i>	
Laura McDowell.	408
<i>Participatory Film Production as Media Practice</i>	
Antoni Roig Telo	427

PART 5: LABOR, FUNDING, AND PROMOTION

<i>Indie Cinema and Short Film Assemblage</i>	
Thomas Barker	449
<i>Independent Canadian Music in the Streaming Age</i>	
Andrew deWaard, Brian Fauteux, and Brianne Selman	459
<i>Crowdfunding for Independent Print Media: E-Commerce, Marketing, and Business Development</i>	
Peter Konhäusner, Marius Thielmann, Veronica Thielmann, Veronica Câmpian, and Dan-Cristian Dabija	489
<i>'Let's Keep Music Special. F—Spotify': On-Demand Streaming and the Controversy over Artist Royalties</i>	
Lee Marshall	513
<i>DIY or Die? A Typology of DIY Careers in the Portuguese Independent Music Scenes</i>	
Ana Oliveira	528
<i>The Political Economy of Financially Successful Independent Hip-Hop Artists</i>	
Geoff Ostrove.	544
<i>Autonomy, Integration, and the Work of Cultural Intermediation in Indie Games</i>	
Matthew E. Perks, Felan Parker, Jennifer R. Whitson, Gabrielle Lavenir, Ceyda Yolgörmez, Pierson Browne, and Brian Schram	564
<i>Seeking Deep Relations in a Precarious Industry: Addressing Mental Health through Independent Videogame Development</i>	
Paulo Ruffino	584

PART 6: MESSAGES, NARRATIVES, AND REPRESENTATIONS

<i>What I Know Now: Radio as a Means of Empowerment for Women of Lived Prison Experience</i>	
Heather Anderson and Charlotte Bedford.	603

<i>Are You Okay? Mental Health Narratives in Art Zines from the Zineopolis Collection</i>	
Jackie Batey	619
<i>"I Want to Tell You about My Life Now": The Voice of Palestinian Refugees in Frontiers of Dreams and Fears</i>	
Catherine Burwell	633
<i>American Realities on Public Television: Analysis of the Independent Television Service's Documentaries, 2007-2016</i>	
Caty Borum Chattoo, Patricia Aufderheide, Michele Alexander, and Chandler Green	647
<i>Against Hollywood: American Independent Film as a Critical Cultural Movement</i>	
Sherry B. Ortner.	670
<i>Alternative Media, Self-Representation and Arab-American Women</i>	
Kenza Oumlil	689

PART 7: AUDIENCES: PARTICIPATION, ENGAGEMENT, AND ACCESS

<i>Conventions, Computers, and Collective Action (1991-2007)</i>	
Francesca Coppa	709
<i>Coming Out as Popular Media Practice: The Politics of Queer Youth Coming Out on YouTube</i>	
Sander De Ridder and Frederik Dhaenens	743
<i>Public Value and Participation of Civil Society—A Case for Public Service or Community Media?</i>	
Manuela Grünangerl, Josef Trappel, and Corinna Wenzel.	759
<i>Moments of Danger: The Struggle for Community-based Public Radio in Baltimore</i>	
Jason Loviglio.	784
<i>Making Media Public: On Revolutionary Street Screenings in Egypt</i>	
Nina Grønlykke Mollerup and Sherief Gaber	800
<i>The Death of Indie Hip-Hop?:The Blurry Lines Between the Majors and Independent Hip-Hop</i>	
Christopher Vito	815

PART 8: JOURNALISM AND THE PUBLIC

<i>Podcasting as Public Media: The Future of U.S. News, Public Affairs, and Educational Podcasts</i> Patricia Aufderheide, David Lieberman, Atika Alkhallouf, and Jiji Majiri Ugboma	841
<i>The Future of Public Service Media and the Internet</i> Alessandra D'Arma, Christian Fuchs, Minna Horowitz, and Klaus Unterberger	861
<i>Community Radio and Peace-building in Kenya</i> Jessica Gustafsson	871
<i>Intersectionality in Autonomous Journalism Practices</i> Sandra Jeppesen and Media Action Research Group	887
<i>Amplifying Counter-Public Spheres on Social Media: News Sharing of Alternative Versus Traditional Media After the 2019 Chilean Uprising</i> Juan Pablo Luna, Sergio Toro, and Sebastián Valenzuelap	906
<i>Iranian Internet Cinema, a Cinema of Embodied Protest: Imperfect, Amateur, Small, Unauthorized, Global</i> Hamid Naficy	926
<i>Media Representations of Burundi's 2020 Elections in Belgium and Burundi</i> Caroline Williamson Sinalo	941
<i>Digital Amplification of Fringe Voices: Alternative Media and Street Politics in Hong Kong</i> Yidong Wang	959

PART 9: COMMUNITY AND LOCALISM

<i>Not Just Surviving but Thriving: Practices That Sustain a New Generation of Latin American Community Media Makers</i> Diana Coryat	983
<i>Community Media Makers and the Mediation of Difference: Claiming Citizenship and Belongingness</i> Lola de Koning, Elaine Nolten, and Koen Leurs	999
<i>Failities at the Borders: Stalled Activist Media Projects in East Africa</i> Christina Dunbar-Hester	1015
<i>Wireless Mesh Networks as Community Hubs: Analysis of Small-Scale Wireless Mesh Networks and Community-Centered Technology Training</i> Jamie Alexander Greig	1035

<i>'Neither Silent Nor Invisible': Anti-poverty Communication in the San Francisco Bay Area</i>	
Dorothy Kidd and Bernadette Barker-Plummer	1063
<i>Core Dimensions of Community Radio in Action: The Case of Ghana</i>	
Lawrence Naaikuur and Africanus L. Diedong	1077
<i>Communicative Sovereignty in Latin America: The Case of Radio Mundo Real</i>	
Katherine Reilly	1096
<i>Combatting Cultural 'Nerve Gas': Maintaining Traditional Media and Culture through Local Media Production in Australia, Canada and Mexico</i>	
Ian Watson	1115

PART 10: NETWORKS AND SOCIAL MEDIA

<i>Activist Networks</i>	
Joshua D. Atkinson.	1133
<i>Why Diverse Zines Matter: A Case Study of the People of Color Zines Project</i>	
Melanie Ramdarshan Bold	1157
<i>FCJ-193 Harboursing Dissent: Greek Independent and Social Media and the Antifascist Movement</i>	
Sky Croeser and Tim Highfield	1172
<i>The Case for Alternative Social Media</i>	
Robert W. Gehl	1189
<i>The Opium of the Paquete: State Censorship, Private Self-Censorship, and the Content-Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Emergent, Independent Digital-Media Start-Ups</i>	
Ted A. Henken.	1209
<i>Bridging the Open Web and APIs: Alternative Social Media Alongside the Corporate Web</i>	
Jack Jamieson, Naomi Yamashita, and Rhonda McEwen	1233
<i>Building Wi-Fi Networks for Communities: Three Canadian Cases</i>	
Catherine Middleton and Barbara Crow	1254

PART 11: ACTIVISM AND RESISTANCE

<i>Punks' Jungle: São Paulo</i>	
Rodrigo Lopes de Barros	1281
<i>The Lumad Struggle for Social and Environmental Justice: Alternative Media in a Socio-Environmental Movement in the Philippines</i>	
Belinda F. Espiritu	1315

<i>Indymedia and the Long Story of Rebellion Against Neoliberal Capitalism</i>	
Natalie Fenton	1332
<i>Bearing Witness to Authoritarianism and Commoning through Video</i>	
<i>Activism and Political Film-Making after the Gezi Protests</i>	
Özge Özdüzen	1339
<i>Alternative Media in Latin American Grassroots Integration: Building</i>	
<i>Networks and New Agendas</i>	
Daniela Parra	1355
<i>Feminist Media as Alternative Media? Theorising Feminist Media from the</i>	
<i>Perspective of Alternative Media Studies</i>	
Jenny Gunnarsson Payne	1374
<i>Media Activism from Above and Below: Lessons From the 1940s American</i>	
<i>Reform Movement</i>	
Victor Pickard.	1390
<i>Queer Blogs and Digital Archives: A Tactical Shift Towards Queer Utopia in Bangladesh</i>	
Mohammed Mizanur Rashid	1405

Indymedia and the Long Story of Rebellion Against Neoliberal Capitalism

Natalie Fenton

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Abstract

Indymedia was born of the anti-globalisation movement of the late 1990s and quickly spread to become a social movement in its own right. This article reflects on how prescient the claims of the anti-globalisation movement have proven to be and how 20 years ago Indymedia and the anti-globalisation movement predicted there was trouble ahead and that neoliberalism was a central part of the problem. It notes how a history of struggle and protest emanating from the days of Indymedia has developed over time building a counter-politics that is becoming ever wiser about the multiple intersectional harms of capitalism and ever more sophisticated in its political response. The challenge is what comes next.

Keywords

activism, anti-globalisation, Indymedia, Internet, neoliberalism, protest

Indymedia is now part of history—something to look back on fondly and mull over the good old days when protest seemed to matter and the Internet still held the promise of revolutionary potential. It was born of the anti-globalisation movement of the late 1990s and quickly spread to become a social movement in its own right. It came into the public consciousness at what became known as ‘The Battle of Seattle’ on 30 November 1999 (Fenton, 2016). As an alliance of labour and environmental activists congregated in Seattle in opposition to

the neoliberal politics of the World Trade Organisation (WTO), little did they know that just under 10 years later we would be in the grips of a financial crisis brought about by some of the very forces they were objecting to. Although the Battle of Seattle was portrayed by much of the mainstream media as a group of anarchists hell-bent on destruction, in reality the anti-globalisation movement was made up of non-governmental organisations (NGOs), debt campaigners, students and indigenous peoples, all finding common cause in the harms committed by forms of trade liberalisation that undermine local economies, decimate communities and serve global corporate expansion above all else (Downing, 2003). How very prescient.

Twenty years later, neoliberalism has run amok. The brutal form of capitalism that many of us now exist within has massively increased global and national inequality with the accumulation of wealth in ever fewer hands (Dorling, 2014; Oxfam, 2019) and has led to more precarious and insecure labour (Armstrong, 2018), with increases in poverty (Armstrong, 2018; Piketty, 2014) and massive environmental degradation as a result of extractive relations to nature (IPCC, 2018) alongside the hollowing out of democracy by market forces (Brown, 2015). And as Fraser and Jaeggi (2018) note, it has involved ‘the corporate capture of political parties and public institutions at the level of the territorial state . . . [and] . . . the usurpation of political decision making power at the transnational level by global finance’ (p. 3).

Twenty years ago, the protest against the neoliberal policies that contributed to the current crises was huge, transnational and fast moving. A petition of more than 1700 groups, mostly from the Global South, was raised within a day to object to how the WTO talks were being conducted. At the time, it was believed to be one of the largest and fastest responses ever on a global protest issue made possible because of digital communications (Halleck, 2002). Back then, that seemed to count. Now of course, hundreds of thousands can sign petitions from all over the world and no one blinks an eye. This was followed by a march of more than 5000 people led by steelworkers, trade unions and students indicative of a new mode of coalition building and an increased awareness that neoliberal trade policy was destroying livelihoods around the world and wreaking havoc on the environment. Simultaneously, it was claimed that nearly 1200 NGOs in 87 countries called for the wholesale reform of the WTO staging their own protests wherever they were located. The Internet became a crucial part of their strategies. The Independent Media Centre, itself a coalition of different alternative media groups and activists, was formed to provide grassroots coverage and counter mainstream misrepresentations, respond to journalists, and distribute up to the minute reports, video footage, photos and audio. As one activist said, ‘Indymedia goes to where the silences are’ (cited in Pickard, 2006: 20). During the Seattle demonstration, the site logged more than 2 million hits and was featured on major news outlets. This was collective citizen journalism combined with Internet activism, and it worked. Independent Media Centres sprang up on every continent connecting protests around the world, building participation in the movement and bringing people news and information they were unable to get from the mainstream media while attempting to provide non-hierarchical and inclusive forms of media production, at a speed that was unprecedented (Pickard, 2006). Indymedia was exciting and hopeful: this was the moment that democratic, non-corporate, citizen-controlled media production could flourish—it had a movement to organise around and a platform to distribute from (Kidd, 2003). Yet, 20 years on things have only got worse—we are faced with massive and unprec-

edented inequality, exasperated citizens in degenerative democracies with deeply degraded public spheres—so did Indymedia fail? What sense can we make of this as media scholars?

While the protests may change and the media activism adapts to the technological environment it is part of, the same questions about who holds the balance of power pertain now as they did then. The media activist is able to use digital media to mobilise social protest but seems unlikely to be able to overthrow global capitalism. And while alternative media producers can circulate oppositional and counter-hegemonic content with increasing ease, legacy media still dominates the media landscape (Media Reform Coalition (MRC), 2018). Even after Indymedia's heyday, when digital activism was sometimes (and wrongly) credited with sole responsibility for the uprisings that came to be known as the Arab Spring, more measured analyses have noted how elite power often works behind our backs and out of view and is largely unaffected by major forms of protest that have followed in the anti-globalisation movement's wake (such as Occupy, the Umbrella movement and pro-democracy protests in Hong Kong, and climate change strikes across many nations). We have more protest than ever before and more radical media sites, production and distribution than ever before, yet we also have to recognise that global inequalities between the rich and the poor, the powerful and the powerless are increasing while environmental degradation continues apace.

One simple response is that as inspiring and exciting as digital activism can be, technology alone is never the answer if global capitalism is the problem. Digital activism may begin with a revolutionary impulse but too often becomes the end focus itself as the means of communication is invested with the ability to undermine dominant power and challenge authority. However radical alternative media is and digital activism can be, turned inwards it becomes fragmentary and loses sight of the broader politics and solidarity building required to form counter-hegemonic blocs and shift power. Some media theorists were lured into the same trap and too quickly heralded new technology as political saviour. Much of this literature chimes with Castells' argument that the Internet offers multiple prospects for intervention and manipulation coming from a myriad of social nodes that can combine to create a new symbolic counter-force capable of shifting dominant power relations and empowering sovereign audiences through the creative autonomy bestowed upon them. Ultimately, Castells (2009) suggests this could provide 'the material and cultural basis for the anarchist utopia of networked self-management to become a social practice' (p. 346) such that 'significant political change will result, in due time, from the actions of networked social movements' (p. 312). Such accounts depend on the implicit assumptions about the consequential relations between networked communications and political demands that will result in social and political change. But the political demands were often unclear. The radical democratic politics on which Indymedia operated sought to diminish structural inequalities and be dynamically decentralised, non-hierarchical, inclusive and open—a politics deemed well-suited to the architecture of the Internet. Hence, although many of the activists involved were vehemently opposed to corporate capitalism, they were reluctant to organise around this principle for fear of adopting what could be seen as yet another totalising and exclusionary grand narrative.

Twenty years on and few remain in thrall to the revolutionary potential of the Internet that has been well and truly captured by capitalism. The tech giants dominate our digital lives—Facebook, Alphabet (the parent company of Google), Amazon, Microsoft and Apple together have a combined annual revenue larger than the gross domestic product (GDP) of 90% of the

world's countries (Lawrence and Laybourn-Langton, 2019). Apple is the first trillion-dollar company in history. Jeff Bezos, the founder and owner of Amazon, is the richest person in history, with his net wealth increasing by US\$400 million a day in 2018. These corporations form the largest oligopolies the world has ever seen. They are resistant to traditional forms of regulation and are largely out of reach of democratically organised political will-formation.

Meanwhile, Facebook is fast becoming the dominant digital platform for news. Google has some 90% of global desktop search, and Google and Facebook together account for around two-thirds of all digital advertising in the United States (eMarketer, 2019). According to the Wall Street Journal (2017), 85 cents of every dollar spent on digital advertising in America goes to Google and Facebook, evidence of a concentration of market power in two companies that not only own the playing field but are able to set the rules of the game as well. And in 2019 they soaked up 67% of the world's digital ad spend (eMarketer, 2019). These companies are not only the most concentrated forms of media ownership we have ever seen, but they are also key to the contemporary condition of advanced capitalism. The bewildering market power wielded by the likes of Google and Facebook has not come at the expense of the influence of mainstream press and broadcasters. Google, Facebook and Twitter are, if anything, reinforcing the agenda-setting power of the mainstream news brands by facilitating their increased circulation through algorithms. The gatekeeping power of Google and Facebook works in tandem with that of mainstream news providers, mutually reinforcing each other around what they consider to be real, legitimate and authoritative news (MRC, 2018).

Technology may not be the answer, but the politics that Indymedia and the anti-globalisation movement were campaigning against did point us in the right direction. Continued deregulation of the market has enabled the amassing of global corporate capital and huge economic inequality. In 2011, the Occupy movement took this politics further and linked inequality directly to the demise of democracy. But still the likes of the WTO aim to maximise the flow of international trade uninhibited by national policies that may seek to protect the national interest and the public good to the advantage of mega global corporations (including media and tech corporations). Global capitalist geo-political hegemonies are ever more entrenched. Most recently, we have seen this in the form of financialised capitalism that involves a new layer of governance through global financial institutions—the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the World Bank, the WTO, the European Central Bank and bond rating agencies—that set the rules around free trade, are entirely unaccountable and largely untouched by political action at the state level, yet set strict limits on what states can and cannot do. This was made alarmingly clear in the aftermath of the financial crisis of 2008 when these organisations instructed national governments how to order their economies so that banks and financial agencies could recoup the finance they had lent to governments in order to solve the problems they had brought about in the first place through irresponsibly and recklessly encouraging individual debt. As Davis (2019) notes, '[t]he largest transnational corporations and financial institutions now control more funds than most of our largest economies' (p. 47). While nation states are losing control of things such as environmental degradation, climate change, food distribution and energy resources, they are left having to cope with the consequences of reduced corporate taxation, deregulation and a weakened welfare state, leading to more crime, more homelessness, more ill-health and more protest.

Citizens experience this variously as a loss of sovereignty, being over-looked and left behind or simply as feeling irrelevant (CSF, 2018).

The precise configuration of capitalism at any one time is reliant on the dynamic between economic power and political power with citizens having virtually no influence over the former and increasingly being squeezed out of the latter. But Indymedia also taught us that this does not mean that economic power is totalising or that the capitalist state has a single and unified political character. Struggles take place constantly within capitalism and in relation to the state: whether they come from media activists, Black activists, climate activists, anarchists, socialists or feminists. These struggles do not just evaporate into thin air, they leave trails of hope and provide tracks for other movements to take up the baton. In his work on media reform movements, McChesney (2008) argues that the contemporary US media reform movement was triggered by the anti-globalisation struggles which raised serious questions about the incorporation of the right to communicate within neoliberal frames and policies in which Indymedia was key. The reverberations did not stop there.

In 2018, the teenager Greta Thunberg went on strike from school in Stockholm Sweden in response to the lack of government action about climate breakdown. She said she was inspired by the young people in Parkland, Florida, who led a national wave of class walkouts demanding tough controls on gun ownership after 17 people were murdered at their school in February 2018. In turn, Thunberg inspired youth climate strikes in 125 countries across the globe with an estimated 1.6 million young people participating. As heroic as Thunberg is, she is not a lone traveller but part of a transnational response that has been building over decades. The anti-globalisation movement and Indymedia were part of this history of struggle and protest that grows and develops over time building a counter-politics that is becoming ever wiser about the intersectional harms of capitalism and ever more sophisticated in its political response.

The latest environmental movements seem to be gathering more public support. In the United Kingdom, Extinction Rebellion has sparked a raft of direct action and civil disobedience that has quickly spread. In the United States, the Sunrise Movement occupied the office of Nancy Pelosi demanding Congress immediately adopt a rapid decarbonisation framework (Klein, 2019). Although climate change activism has a long history, the difference now is that capitalism is evidently failing on multiple fronts and people are beginning to join the dots. As Naomi Klein notes, the destruction of the planet goes hand in hand with the destruction of people's lives in other ways, from wage stagnation, to gaping inequalities to crumbling services, to the rise of the far-right and the collapse of our information ecology, and all are marked by race, gender and class. It is the system of global capitalism that needs to change, and more and more people know it. Everywhere you look, in neoliberal economies around the world, the stark contradiction of growing inequalities between rich and poor while striving for economic growth against all odds, with dire consequences for the planet and its inhabitants, is finally being understood. A market-driven politics that drives ever higher production output, ever worse labour conditions and demands ever increasing consumption has come up against the demise of collective services on which democracy depends, including news and information provision.

Twenty years ago, Indymedia and the anti-globalisation movement knew there was trouble ahead and that neoliberalism was part of the problem. They started to set out the hard edges

of the jigsaw. Twenty years on, it is abundantly clear that neoliberalism is not working for the vast majority of people, many of whom are beginning to acknowledge that global capitalism is the cause and are beginning to rebel against an economic system hell-bent on profit at the expense of their futures. The pieces of the jigsaw are beginning to fall into place and the picture is not pretty. Over the next 20 years, we need to break it up and start anew.

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